

when given reasonable constraints, we operate better than if everything was a limitless free-for-all.

The last concept is about auditing and maintaining community. It's what I like to call **holding relationships with an open hand**. We can care for ourselves relationally and experience quality community when we allow this very living organism to grow, morph, and shift. It involves tending to our network regularly but giving space for things to change, people to transition, and our own needs to evolve.

When we weave together these concepts of self-understanding, boundaries, and open-handedness with our relationships and spending, we can show up emotionally and financially healthy in our four main groups of relationships.

With Our Families

For those you share a household with, collaboration, negotiation, and a willingness to honor each other's needs, even if you don't fully understand them, is important. Each person brings their own background with money, values, and behaviors to the table, and that mix may or may not be compatible with yours or helpful to your combined financial landscape. Using income and individual values as parameters can be useful for creating spending plans that benefit you both.

When it comes to our long-term partners and spouses, finances are an integral part in the health of those relationships. Power dynamics, roles, lifestyle, methods of communication, patterns of relating, care, and value shown and so much more *all* intersect with money among couples. It's no wonder there are whole books written on finances just for couples!

This category of community plays one of the biggest roles in our day-to-day spending and trajectory of our financial futures. It should be given great attention and care. No person or relationship is perfect, and we'll all find ourselves at odds with our partner eventually, especially on how money gets spent. There are a lot of ways to manage finances as a couple; we have a few recommendations listed on the resources page of this book at frugalfriendspodcast.com/book. We encourage you to find the best method for both of you, despite what other couples around you tell you about how they manage their money.